What remains of the

JOURNEY



Fig. — Pasture, end of the afternoon. Pixel art by Vekon, in a single ink.

NO. 009
256 × 144 PX
ONE INK

A MANIFESTO

I / II

A human life, when things go well, lasts something close to eighty years. We do not begin to inhabit it at birth. The first years are almost entirely erased, and what we call a self only takes hold in memory at around seven. Set those years aside and the arithmetic is simple. At seventeen, what remains is about six times the time already remembered. At twenty-seven, a little more than two and a half times. At thirty-seven, less than one and a half. Shortly after forty, what is left becomes smaller than what has passed, and that does not reverse.

This arithmetic is true and almost useless. It treats time as a straight line cut into equal parts, and no lived time has that shape. Augustine observed that the past exists nowhere except as memory, and the future only as expectation; what we have is a present that stretches backward and forward inside us.[1] A year lasts as long as what remains of it. Some months fit in a single sentence, and some afternoons take up an enormous place in memory. A week in which everything was new weighs more, seen from a distance, than years in which nothing stood out. The clock measures something else.

If this is so, the count that matters is a different one: what we will make happen in the time that is left. Seneca thought the complaint about the shortness of life was misplaced, and that life would be long enough for anyone who knew how to use it.[2] Perhaps he exaggerated. But he was looking in the right place.

"In te, anime meus, tempora metior."

It is in you, my mind, that I measure time.

[1] AUGUSTINE, CONFESSIONS XI.27

"Non exiguum temporis habemus, sed multum perdidimus."

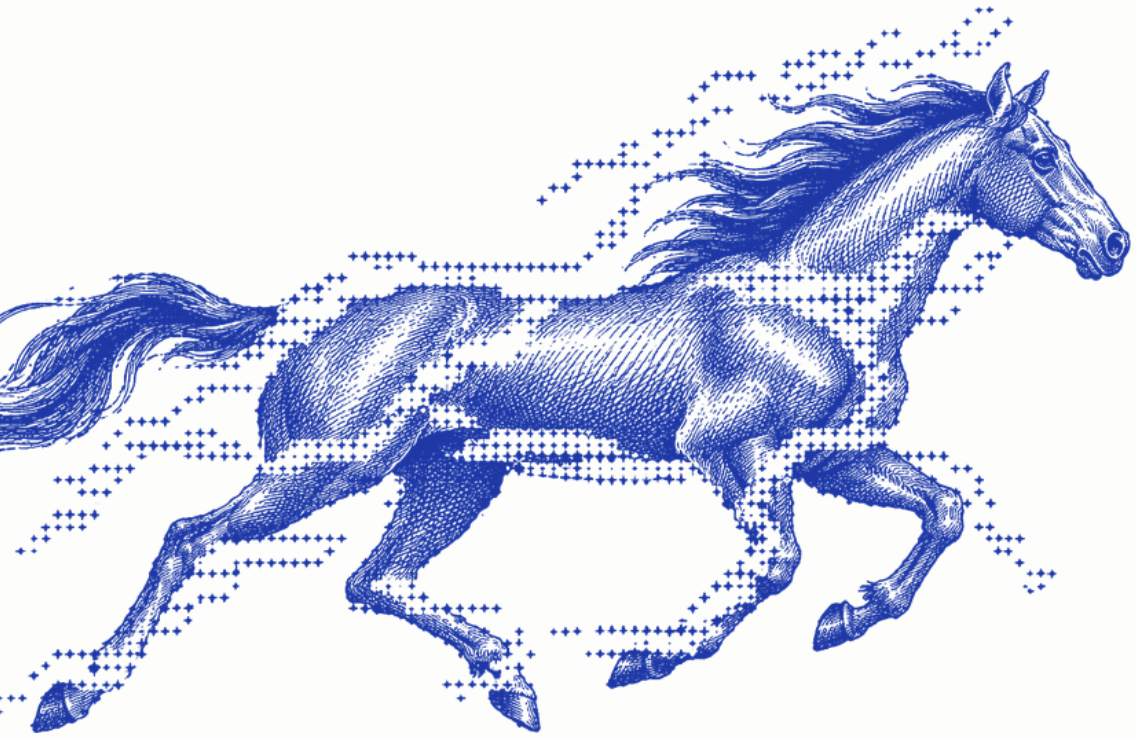
We do not have a short time; we lose a great deal of it.

[2] SENECA, ON THE SHORTNESS OF LIFE I.3

CONTINUED ON SHEET II →

On a journey that does not stop,

PASSENGERS



II / II

One thing must be said without softening it: we are always choosing. To live is to distribute hours among possibilities. Every hour given to one thing has been taken from all the others. An afternoon spent working is not spent by the sea, and an afternoon by the sea is not spent working. Neither is the wrong one. Bills exist, and they weigh, but their weight acts on a choice without replacing it. It would be possible to want less or to want more, to change cities, trades, company. It would be possible, with time and some cost, to become someone else. Often the alternatives are poor, and some are out of reach. Among those that remain, one is always being chosen, including the choice to stay. Not choosing is one of the available choices, and usually the most frequent.

What we do does not pass through us without leaving a mark. There is not first a person and then the hours that person spends; the person is made by the hours. We come to resemble the places where we stay, the people we live among, the kind of attention our days demand. Someone who spends years calculating learns to see the world as calculation. Someone who spends years caring for another learns something else. This is why changing what one does is, slowly, changing who one is, at twenty or at seventy. And this is why the question of who we are has a less mysterious answer than it seems. It is written in the way we spend our days.

None of this guarantees that life will be good. There will be hours given to things no one would want. We will be miserable for stretches, sometimes long ones, and at other moments we will touch something that seems to justify everything. The sum rarely balances. Some lives hold more sadness than joy, and there is no one to appeal to. The world is not fair, and most of what happens to us was chosen by no one. What falls to us is to choose among the options that remain. The meaning of a life does not depend on which of the two wins. It depends on the hours having gone, as far as was possible, to what we recognize as our own. A sad life can have meaning, and a comfortable life can have none.

Metaphors are often crude, but this one may help. We are on a journey that does not stop. We did not choose the hour of departure, we do not know the destination, and the speed increases as we go, because each year is a smaller fraction of everything we have already seen. No one gets off before the end. We are passengers. But a passenger decides where to look, whom to talk to, what to keep of the landscape, which carriage to sit in. The speed does not belong to us. What remains of the journey, for the most part, does.

In the end, what we propose is a catalogue of memories. This is Vekon, and this is how we understand a life: hours that are always being chosen, a person made by them, and a journey worth keeping and returning to.



Text and engravings: Vekon. A manifesto, 2026.